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That’s Fit to Print”

# The New York Times



Leah Lauchlan early this month during a “Kids Farm Day” event at Aberlin Springs, a community of food and health-system skeptics.

## Potential Risks In Banks’ Shift Toward Crypto

**By ROB COPELAND**

Not long ago, bank executives would compete with one another to be the loudest critic of cryptocurrencies.

Jamie Dimon, the chief executive of JPMorgan Chase, once compared Bitcoin to a pet rock and said the whole crypto industry should be banned. Bank of America’s Brian Moynihan described the space as an “untraceable tool for money laundering,” while HSBC’s chief executive proclaimed bluntly: “We are not into Bitcoin.”

Now big banks can’t stop talking about crypto.

In investor calls, public presentations and meetings with Washington regulators, financial executives are tripping over one another to unveil new plans — including the development of fresh cryptocurrencies under bank umbrellas and loans tied to digital assets.

There’s no small mix of political opportunism at play, given that President Trump and his family are vociferous crypto boosters and investors. And of course there is a degree of old-fashioned jealousy among the traditional finance set at the riches earned by onetime fringe companies and investors as Bitcoin more than doubled over the past year to blow past \$100,000.

But behind the scenes at major financial institutions — and in stark contrast to the public showboating among chief executives — fear is also rising that the rush into crypto may risk the safety of personal bank accounts in ways that Wall Street and Washington are just beginning to understand.

The worries, described by nine Wall Street executives briefed on their organizations’ crypto initiatives but not authorized to speak publicly for their employers, center on the creation of a new interbank checking account and payments system built on crypto and blockchain technology. That system would come with few consumer protections and nascent regulatory oversight.

The system, being sketched out by top executives and lawyers at huge banks, including JPMorgan, Bank of America and Citi, involves a complicated corner of the crypto ecosystem called a stablecoin.

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## Ohio Farm Enclave Is Mecca for ‘MAHA Mom’

**By CAROLINE KITCHENER**

MORROW, Ohio — When the moms decided to move to the farm, they imagined a thousand mornings like this one. Birds chirping. Pesticide-free vegetables growing. And children, many children, roaming the land without phones or ultraprocessed snacks.

“You guys want to gather up? Let’s do a quick lesson first,” said Leah Lauchlan, the mother who would lead “Kids Farm Day” on a Tuesday in midsummer. A gaggle of neighborhood children had arrived early on bicycles and tricycles, and were already plopped down in the dirt, pulling weeds.

### Skeptics From the Right and Left Striving for Political Harmony

“Soil supports 95 percent of all food production,” said Ms. Lauchlan, holding a coffee mug that read, “MRS.” Trim, tanned and toned, the 42-year-old mother of five looked ready to shoot an athleisure commercial, pairing spandex and sneakers with shimmering eye shadow and large gold hoops. “If the soil isn’t healthy,” she added, “then the food isn’t healthy — and then the people aren’t

healthy.”

Several mothers and their children gather in this spot twice a week, amid cucumber and tomato vines they have planted themselves on a plot next to a small working farm. Most live just a short walk away, in custom-built homes with painted shutters and rocking chairs out front, on roads with names like “Nectar Court” and “Lavender Way.”

Ms. Lauchlan and her husband were one of the first couples to buy a home in 2018 at Aberlin Springs, an “agri-community” in southwest Ohio, commuting distance from downtown Cincinnati. The development includes almost 100

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The Macarena, a figure of the Virgin Mary in Spain, was given longer eyelashes and a smokier gaze.

## A Face-Lift That Not Even a Mother Could Love

**By JASON HOROWITZ**

SEVILLE, Spain — The Macarena needed to get some work done.

On this, many in Seville, a city with a die-hard devotion to a sorrowful 17th-century wooden statue of the Virgin Mary, agreed. In June, members of the Brotherhood of the Macarena, entrusted for centuries with protecting the image, sent her out from her shrine for some touch-ups.

But the Macarena — pro-

### Uproar After Makeover of a Sacred Statue

nounced just like the song belted by a local duo that conquered ballparks and bar mitzvahs throughout the 1990s — came back from a restorer’s workshop with a full eye job.

Her glow-up gave her longer lashes, a smokier look in her gaze and changes to her skin and nose. Outrage among locals, many wearing Macarena medal-

lions and bracelets, spread to Seville tapas bars adorned with Macarena posters, where television sets play the Macarena’s pre-Easter procession on a continuous loop.

“It was not good work,” Salvador Fernández, 84, a longtime brotherhood member, said with anguish on a recent morning after bowing before the Macarena, who wept her glass tears in the high altar in the basilica that bears her name.

“It was like she got makeup,” his wife, Consuelo Murga, 75,

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## Frantic Week Of Diplomacy For Zelensky

### Sought a Voice, if Not a Seat, in Trump Talks

**By CONSTANT MÉHEUT**

KYIV, Ukraine — President Volodymyr Zelensky of Ukraine was returning from the front line last week when he joined a pivotal call with President Trump.

Hours earlier, Mr. Zelensky had visited soldiers defending Ukraine’s northeastern Sumy region against Russian ground assaults. Now, stopping in the small city of Romny, he listened on a secure line with other European leaders as Mr. Trump outlined Russia’s proposal to end the war.

Moscow, Mr. Trump told them, was ready to halt hostilities under a deal involving a territorial exchange between Russia and Ukraine, according to a Kyiv-based European diplomat and a top Ukrainian official who were briefed on the call and spoke on the condition of anonymity to discuss sensitive information. Seeing a chance to broker peace, Mr. Trump told those on the line that he would meet one on one with President Vladimir V. Putin of Russia to try to seal an agreement.

Mr. Trump had just brought into play two of Kyiv’s deepest fears: that it would be forced to cede land to Russia as part of a peace deal, and that Mr. Putin would be given a way out of his diplomatic isolation. It was a direct challenge to Ukraine’s core principles that territorial issues be addressed only after a cease-fire and that no deal be concluded without Kyiv.

After Mr. Zelensky left the call, he recorded his usual evening address to Ukrainians, trying to project optimism. “I spoke with President Trump,” he said, speaking from a playground in Romny as the sun set behind him. “Russia now seems to be more inclined toward a cease-fire — the pressure is working.”

But he cautioned, “The key is to ensure they don’t deceive anyone in the details — neither us, nor the United States.”

What followed was a week of frantic diplomacy as Ukraine scrambled to avoid being sidelined in the negotiations and to prevent Russia from dictating the terms of peace talks. Mr. Zelensky spoke with nearly 30 world leaders, while his top advisers met online and in person with senior Eu-

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## SETTLER ATTACKS HIT PALESTINIANS IN THE WEST BANK

### 130 ASSAULTS A MONTH

### Intimidation From Israeli Outposts as the World Focuses on Gaza

*This article is by Patrick Kingsley, Fatima AbdulKarim and Natan Odenheimer.*

BURQA, West Bank — It was well past midnight when the masked arsonists sneaked into the hilltop Palestinian village of Burqa. Arriving from the direction of a nearby Israeli settlement, they crept inside a junkyard on the edge of the village.

They sprayed liquid on several cars, security footage showed, and set the vehicles alight. One sprayed graffiti on a barn wall, tagging the name of a nearby settlement, as well as the Hebrew word for “revenge.”

It was the third attack that July night in this central pocket of the Israeli-occupied West Bank, and the seventh attack on this particular junkyard since the start of the war in Gaza in October 2023, according to its owner.

“Before the war they harassed us, but not like this,” said Muhammad Sabr Asalaya, 56, the junkyard owner. “Now, they’re trying to expel as many people as they can and annex as much land as they can.”

Such attacks were on the rise before Hamas led a deadly raid on Israel in 2023, setting off the war in Gaza, and they have since become the new normal across much of the West Bank. With the world’s attention on Gaza, extremist settlers in the West Bank are carrying out one of the most violent and effective campaigns of intimidation and land grabbing since Israel occupied the territory during the Arab-Israeli war of 1967.

Settlers carried out more than 750 attacks on Palestinians and their property during the first half of this year, an average of nearly 130 assaults a month, according to records compiled by the United Nations Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs. That is the highest monthly average since the United Nations started compiling such records in 2006.

The Israeli military has re-

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## Study Deciphers the Inner Voice Of Patients Severed From Speech

**By CARL ZIMMER**

For decades, neuroengineers have dreamed of helping people who have been cut off from the world of language.

A disease like amyotrophic lateral sclerosis, or A.L.S., weakens the muscles in the airway. A stroke can kill neurons that normally relay commands for speaking. Perhaps, by implanting electrodes, scientists could instead record the brain’s electric activity and translate that into spoken words.

Now a team of researchers has made an important advance toward that goal. Previously they succeeded in decoding the signals produced when people tried to speak. In the new study, published on Thursday in the journal *Cell*, their computer often made correct guesses when the subjects simply imagined saying words.

Christian Herff, a neuroscientist at Maastricht University in the Netherlands who was not involved in the research, said the result went beyond the merely technological and shed light on the mystery of language. “It’s a fantastic advance,” Dr. Herff said.

The new study is the latest re-

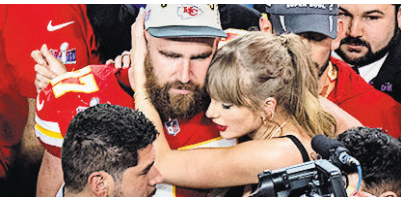


Casey Harrell uses a brain-machine interface to converse.

sult in a long-running clinical trial, called BrainGate2, that has already seen some remarkable successes. One participant, Casey Harrell, now uses his brain-machine interface to hold conversations with his family and friends.

In 2023, after A.L.S. had made his voice unintelligible, Mr. Harrell agreed to have electrodes implanted in his brain. Surgeons placed four arrays of tiny needles on the left side, in a patch of tissue called the motor cortex. The region becomes active when the

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**Setting the Scene for the Tale**

For Taylor Swift and other stars, podcasts are an appealing alternative to late-night TV and magazines.

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**Struggle for Student Coders**

As companies like Amazon and Microsoft embrace A.I. tools, computer science graduates can’t land jobs.

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**Bangladesh’s Frustrated Hopes**

A year after an autocrat was toppled, a promised election is still months away, and the economy is struggling.

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**Korean Collector, Polish Art**

One of the largest collections outside Poland of posters from the 1950s to the ’80s is at a Seoul museum.

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**OBITUARIES B11-12**

**They Dolled Up Barbies**

Mario Paglino, 52, and Gianni Grossi, 54, designers who turned the figures into artworks that sold for thousands of dollars, died in a car crash.

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**Taking Back Washington?**

President Trump has berated the capital, but the federal government actually controls much of the city.

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**Texas Democrats to Return**

The top Democrat in the Texas House said the battle over redistricting was likely to continue in court.

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**New Faces at Liverpool**

Premier League winners rarely make huge waves in the transfer market, but the club has decided to build from a position of strength, spending over \$338 million to add new players.

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**Learning From the Best**

As he transitions from shortstop to third base, Carlos Correa is studying how three of the best at the position — Matt Chapman, Manny Machado and Nolan Arenado — play it.

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**OPINION A18-19**

**M. Gessen**

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**WEEKEND ARTS C1-10**

**An Homage to Immigration**

St. Patrick’s Cathedral will unveil a mural painted by Adam Cvijanovic, above, that celebrates New York’s newcomers, past and present.

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